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BEHIND THE WHEEL

At Udaipur’s The Oberoi Udaivilas, vintage automobiles reclaim their grandeur **P3**

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Nidhi Adlakha
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Last month, in the UK, Uber partnered with fashion rental app By Rotation to offer last-minute ski and winter outfits. With this service, buyers now have access to over 1,50,000 snow-ready apparel. Prior to this, New York’s democratic socialist Mayor, Zohran Mamdani’s wife Rama Duwaji wore a borrowed vintage funnel-neck wool Balenciaga coat and wide-leg shorts to the swearing-in.

Closer home, actors Vikrant Massey and Janhvi Kapoor have been open about renting outfits for high-profile events. In India, famously home to the big, fat, extravagant Bollywood weddings, brides and guests are discovering the advantages of rented wardrobes. After all, if the iconic Sabyasachi bridal lehenga costs you upwards of ₹4 lakh, renting it is only ₹30,000-₹40,000. Which makes better financial sense for a young couple, especially since many of these outfits are rarely worn after the wedding. As per a recent report by Pune-based firm Market Research Future, the global online clothing rental market is expected to grow from \$3.952 billion (₹34,190 crore) in 2025 to \$11.25 billion (₹97,280 crore) by 2035.

Three years ago, in the brief period that the COVID-19 lockdown was lifted, Hyderabad-based Anaisha Singhvee received six wedding invites, which she realised meant readying over 18 outfits. “I kept thinking about what I was going to do about it as the average cost of a wedding guest outfit that matched my style was about ₹20,000,” says the 29-year-old. “I spent close to ₹3 lakh on all the outfits for these weddings, which were spread across a few months.”

While researching fashion rentals, Anaisha learnt that “India doesn’t have quality premium rentals for designer Indian couture” and that was the seed for Kuro, which she launched in 2021. “A friend, who was a retailer in Ludhiana, helped with our initial inventory and we started off as an Instagram page. We later launched the website,” she says of her fashion rental that now has retail outposts in Delhi and Hyderabad, and she sees 200-plus rental orders a month during peak wedding season.

At Kuro, Anaisha says one can rent apparel (new and pre-loved, both) by Amit Aggarwal, Seema Gujral, Harpreet Narula for 1/10th the price, as well as purchase pre-owned designer outfits at up to 60% off. They also encourage customers to cash



Wear. Post. Return

Indian brides and wedding guests are steering a global fashion shift: turning wardrobe rentals from a niche, and once controversial, idea into a booming industry

in on their closets. “We started off as a fashion rental platform but in 2024 we launched our pre-owned couture vertical,” she says, adding that their most popular category is rental and pre-owned bridal wear.

Meanwhile in New Delhi, Aanchal Saini launched Flyrobe a decade ago when the concept was unheard of. “Heavy investments were made in branding and marketing to introduce this new category and over ₹100 crore has gone into building Flyrobe so far,” says the CEO-director of the rental fashion service that offers new and pre-owned wedding apparel for brides, grooms, and guests. “You can wear your favourite designer – Sabyasachi, Amit Aggarwal, Tarun Tahiliani, Gaurav Gupta – at roughly 15% of the MRP.” While Flyrobe began with renting women’s western wear online through the app, the start-up grew as over “90% of those early western-wear users

eventually moved to renting ethnic wear”. They have a retail store in the city as well.

Aanchal says urban consumers now see renting as a smart choice, not second-best. “The category has expanded to ethnic, bridal, and luxury wear, with both online and offline touchpoints scaling quickly. Demand spikes during wedding seasons and festivals,” she says, adding that the industry is now entering the next decade with value-focussed, sustainability-aware Gen Z brides.

Young guns

Anaisha says young brides in the 24-38 age bracket are leading the game, with maximum demand from Delhi NCR, Hyderabad, Mumbai, Indore and Ahmedabad. “Brides end up spending anywhere between ₹4 lakh to ₹30 lakh on wedding

outfits, which are often locked away in storage after the wedding. Younger brides are inclined towards sustainable and mindful shopping. We have a 30% repeat rate in the wedding guest rental category,” she says.

These factors are also the driving force



(Clockwise from left) Wedding apparel at Flyrobe; Rama Duwaji at Zohran Mamdani’s swearing in; outfits at Kuro; Rent-an-Attire; and a pre-owned Hermes bag at Kuro. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



behind Laveena Laitonjam’s Rent an Attire, a brand she launched in 2015 in Pune. “It started from a personal place. I found myself buying expensive outfits for weddings and special occasions, wearing them once, and then leaving them unused in my wardrobe. At the same time, I was becoming more aware of how much textile waste this creates.” She began by offering curated occasion wear and soon grew into a multi-city fashion rental platform that offers pre-loved designer occasion wear. “Most of our demand comes from wedding-related requirements but over time, we’ve also seen strong interest from make-up artists,

stylists, and event professionals, who rent outfits to build their digital portfolios and create styled content for shoots,” adds Laveena, whose inventory has grown from 300 outfits to 1,500.

A conscious choice

“People are no longer renting just to save money; many are consciously choosing rentals to reduce waste and make more responsible fashion choices. This awareness is especially strong among younger clients,” explains Laveena, adding that there is now demand from tier-II cities such as Nagpur, Jaipur, Dehradun, Lucknow, Indore, and Nashik. In the South, several rental services are operating in Chennai (Rent to Ramp, Kosha, etc.) and smaller cities like Coimbatore and Madurai.

Social media has also played a big role in the segment’s growth. “With reels and pictures being shared widely on platforms like Instagram, people don’t want to repeat outfits they’ve already posted. Renting allows them to experiment with different looks for different occasions,” adds Laveena.

Swetha Poddar, CEO, CandidMen, says the increase in market players has created more demand. She launched the brand in 2017 with new collections for women and men, but pivoted to menswear within six months of the launch. “Women are emotional buyers and men are more logical buyers. While we launched as an online model, we realised customers wanted trials. Initially, I created three trial rooms in my back office and today we have six stores across Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Delhi.” On rent are suits, tuxedos, sherwanis, and Indo-western outfits.

Aanchal says the biggest challenge has always been changing consumer mindset and next, scaling a rental business. “Every outfit must be delivered perfectly, returned, repaired, cleaned, and re-circulated. Inventory management in rentals is far more demanding than retail. After years of educating the market and refining operations, the shift is clear and consumers now understand the value.”

At Rent an Attire, Laveena says a lot of time goes into reassuring customers that rental fashion can be “hygienic, well-maintained, and premium”. Another challenge comes from the rise of fast fashion. “Low-cost, low-quality occasion wear has made people more

comfortable with disposable clothing. We have to constantly educate customers on the long-term value of renting well-made outfits,” says the founder who also offers an annual membership programme (starting at ₹999).

Mumbai-based Khyati Gupta started Sisterhoodofrack as an experimental community on Instagram and eventually launched ReRack in 2023 “to create awareness about the problematic supply chain and how it symbiotically fuels consumption”. For her, bringing in a behavioural change among consumers and also educating them about the process has been key.

She says, “users have preset notions about the rental process being long and tiring where upfront deposits are required or they need to take care of returns or damages. We have made this process simple and users just need to order from our website and choose the duration of the rental sans a deposit.” She offers contemporary fashion, demi-fine jewellery sourced from homegrown brands like Lola by Suman, Essgee, Button Masala, and Arrasa. “We provide home deliveries for pick up and drop, dry cleaning services, and also cover minor damages and stains,” adds Khyati, 34.

Swetha charges clients a deposit (same value of the rental) but does not charge for minor stains, lose stitches etc. “We take care of such issues that can be repaired from our end. But in the case of a permanent stain, burnt or torn garment that cannot be fixed, we do not return the deposit. These cases are rare, maybe one in 1,000 orders.”

Given that most garments such rental platforms deal with are designer, utmost care is taken when handing them over. At CandidMen, Swetha ensures all outfits are dry cleaned and steam ironed before delivery. At ReRack, Khyati too has a pre-delivery sanitation process where the garment is steam ironed, UV sanitised and cleaned.

The 2026 forecast

This year, Khyati predicts the online fashion rental industry “will go through an S curve, where demand will start to rise as more and more users adopt or switch to rentals and ditch fast fashion for good as a result of fatigue”. This is the year of “conscious glamour”, shares Laveena. She adds, “People will become more intentional about what they wear and fashion will also become far more personal and individual-led, moving away from standardised trends. Instead of owning many outfits, there will be a clear preference for fewer, well-chosen pieces that feel special.”

Pune-based real estate professional Harshal Ravindra Baisane started renting occasion wear a year ago and now there is no going back. He chanced upon the trend on Instagram and now rents blazers for meetings, and outfits for weddings and festivals. “For a recent wedding in the family, I rented clothes for ₹10,000 over five days. If I had purchased outfits it would have cost me close to ₹50,000. Renting apparel is a budget-friendly option that gives users better quality clothes. It also ensures no repeats.” Now an enthusiastic promoter of rented wardrobes, he adds, “I tell everyone that my clothes are borrowed.”

pick of the week



The Goddess Edit

Women-led labels take centrestage at The Goddess Edit, a two-day showcase celebrating creativity, community and independent design.

Curated by Supriya and

Shefali Dadabhoy, the edit brings together 15 women entrepreneurs across fashion, lifestyle and craft, offering shoppers a chance to meet the makers.

Till today 11am to 7pm at The Folly at Amethyst, Royapettah.



Art for all

Affordable art arrives in Chennai as curator Srila Chatterjee brings together thangka, pichwai, pattachitra, Gond and sohrai alongside contemporary works. Featuring artists such as

Venkat Raman Singh Shyam and Jogen Chowdhury, the showcase presents original, certified pieces that make collecting approachable for first-time buyers. March 6 to 8, from 11am to 7pm, at The Folly at the Amethyst, Royapettah. Prices from ₹3,000 onwards.



Summer ready

Pallavi Dhyani brings her clothing brand THREE to Chennai. The Spring Summer 2026 collection, Off Grid, is inspired by the rhythm of the sea and slow living. The line brings breathable fabrics and

relaxed silhouettes. The palette moves across brown, lime green, powder blue, baby pink and white, spanning shirts, tops, pants, dresses and coord sets in menswear and womenswear. Priced ₹10,000 onwards. March 6 and 7 at Collage, Rutland Gate, from 11am to 7.30pm



Back to college

The Alumnae Association of Stella Maris College is calling all former students back to campus for a spirited Alumnae Sports Meet 2026. Expect laughter, friendly

rivalry, plenty of nostalgia and games such as throw ball, tug of war, balloon bursting, lucky corner, and ball relay. Reconnect with old mates and relive your college days again. On February 28, from 10am to noon at Stella Maris College, Cathedral Road. For registration, call 9444018051.



Shalini Passi and Shashi Tharoor at the book launch. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

This beautiful life

Reality television personality, Shalini Passi, writes about vulnerability, reinvention, and learning to slow down in her memoir

Geetika Sachdev

Ever since socialite, philanthropist and art patron Shalini Passi appeared on *Fabulous Lives vs Bollywood Wives* on Netflix in 2024, she has become something of a social media sensation – celebrated for her attitude and maximal sartorial choices.

Her unapologetic one-liners such as “I like things more than people” and “I don’t hold grudges, it affects my skin” quickly went viral, with many applauding her candour.

But what looks effortless on screen has taken time. Shalini admits she did not simply wake up one day feeling immune to outside noise. Over the years, she realised that the opinions that unsettled her the most were often about things she could not control anyway. “That’s when I kept returning to integrity, the consistency between my values and my actions,” she says. “If I am intentional about my work,

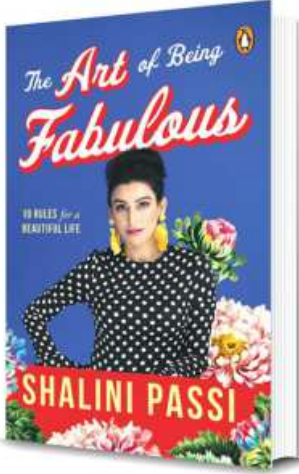
the causes I support, that becomes my anchor. When the external narrative shifts, I’m less affected by it.”

This kind of internal work, she notes, is rarely visible behind the glamour. Her move into writing came when younger women began reaching out to her, wanting to talk about confidence, pressure and expectations. “I realised that the experiences I’d lived through – the fragile ones as well as the empowering ones – might actually be worth sharing. That’s how *The Art of Being Fabulous* came to life,” she says of her debut book, published by Penguin Random House India,



Some of my clearest decisions and most honest creative insights came only when I allowed myself to pause

SHALINI PASSI



which focusses on mindful living and personal growth.

At its unveiling at The Leela Palace, Delhi, Shalini – dressed in a custom sari from designer Ashdeen Lilaowala’s print series – was both nervous and excited. Joining her was politician and author Shashi Tharoor, who spoke about the sensibility she brings to her work. “She reminds us that art can exist in the way

we arrange a room, the way we carry a conversation, or even in how we choose colour and silence,” he notes. “All of that is art.”

For someone deeply involved in the art world, Shalini says art changed how she thinks about beauty. She once saw it as something meant to comfort – but over time, she has come to see how it can also challenge and unsettle. “There’s an emotional courage in the creative process that I admire. It’s made me value long-term vision, experimentation and emotional honesty.”

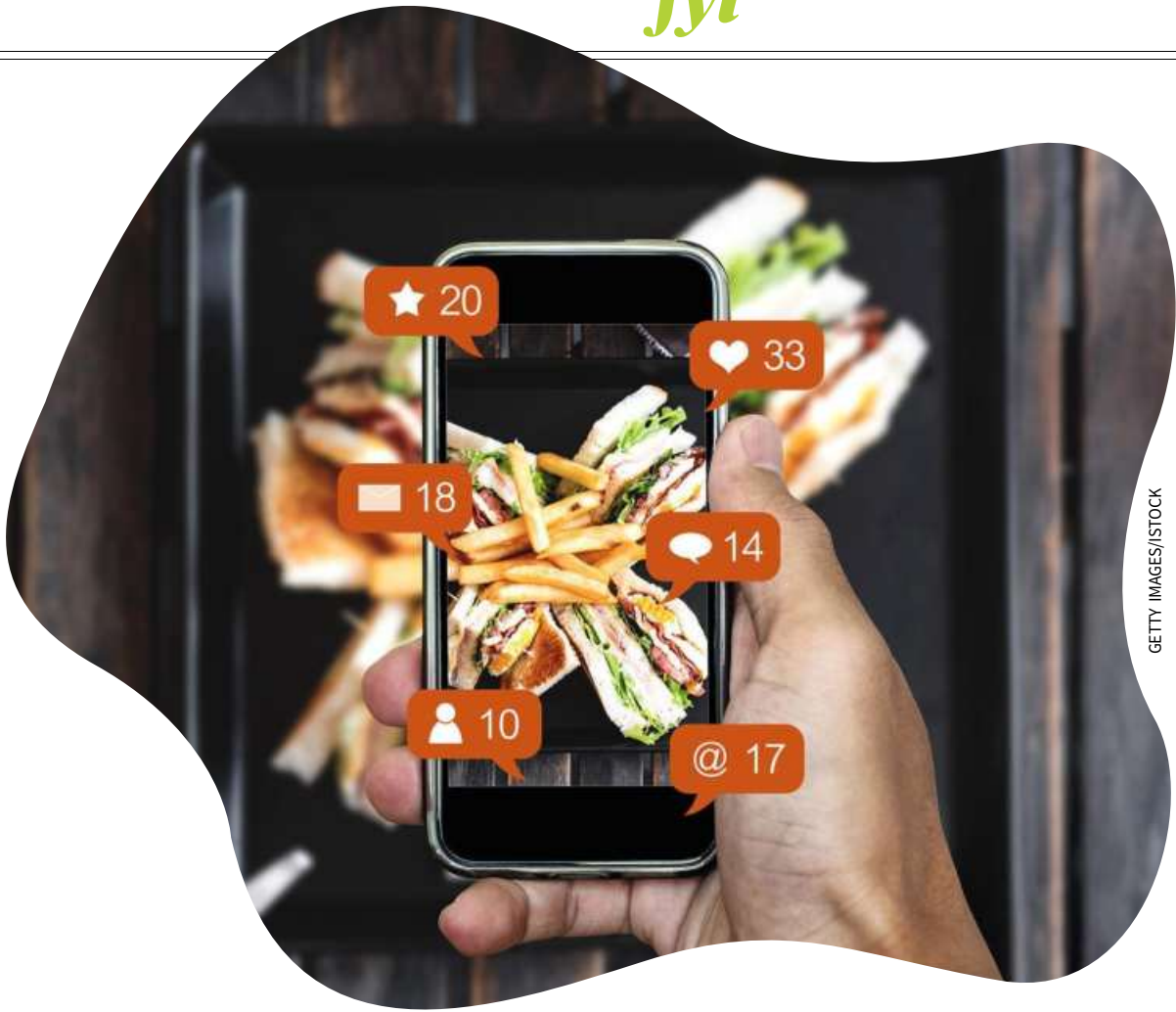
Readers, she believes, may be surprised by how little the book is actually about glamour, and how much it is about discipline, honesty and conscious choices. “Living beautifully rarely happens in the spotlight,” she points out. “It shows up in our daily habits, our relationships, and in the way we choose to treat ourselves.”

Among the ideas she explores, the hardest for her has been learning to slow down. “I kept asking myself what I was really achieving by staying busy,” she admits. “Some of my clearest decisions and most honest creative insights came only when I allowed myself to pause. I don’t think I’ll ever fully master it, and I am okay with that.”

At the same time, she is careful that vulnerability does not become self-indulgent. She shares personal moments only when they might offer strength or perspective.

Ultimately, she hopes readers close the book feeling more comfortable with who they are becoming, rather than who they think they are supposed to be. If there is one idea she hopes to dismantle, it is the belief that there is a formula for beauty, success or a life well-lived. “There isn’t one. And the sooner you make peace with that, the sooner you can begin building something that is genuinely, wholly yours,” she advises.

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AT THE TABLE

This is a restaurant, not a vending machine

When did “share recipe” replace “hello”? Inside the blurred boundaries of Instagram hospitality

message: “Share recipe.”

No please, no maybe. Just, share recipe. A sentence that somehow served as both, a compliment and a demand. As if my role, at that moment, was less than a chef or a restaurateur and more of a content-vending machine.

That small exchange sums up something bigger I’ve been circling for a while. Entitlement created by social media. How the walls between kitchens and

customers, creators and audiences, have come down. And how, like most big shifts, it cuts both ways.

There was a time when access to chefs, owners and kitchens was rare. You booked a table, you ate the food, you maybe caught a glimpse of the chef if they popped out at the end of service. Feedback happened quietly, if at all. If you really felt strongly, you wrote a letter on paper, with a stamp,

and hoped it reached the right hands.

Now, the kitchen door is permanently ajar. The chef is in your pocket and the owner is one DM away. Instagram has turned into a customer service desk, a complaints department and, occasionally, a confessional.

I rarely block people who disagree with me. I don’t mind being challenged. I don’t even mind a bit of bluntness. What I struggle with is impoliteness. That tone of ‘you owe me this’.

Some messages are harmless, but telling: “Send recipe” or “Why don’t you post more vegetarian?”. Others are stranger: “I can’t believe you charge for recipes” or “I don’t want to pay for another subscription, can you email me the recipe.”

When I put recipes behind a paywall, the backlash fascinates me. Not because people don’t want to pay. That’s fair. But because some seem offended by the idea that online content might have value. We’ve somehow decided that it should be free by default, even though we’d never ask an author to send us their books for free or journalists to email their articles because we liked the headline.

Creating good content takes time and effort. Testing recipes takes ingredients, teams, equipment, research, and a lot of trial and error. Add to that filming, editing, writing, posting and answering questions, alongside a day job and family life. Instagram may feel casual, but for many of us it’s work, and part of the job today. A one-minute reel can often take hours to film and days to direct and edit.

When I started Hoppers a decade ago, the job was simple in theory. Cook well, build a happy team, run a tight service and deliver genuine hospitality. Now there is an additional layer. Document it all, caption it, be upbeat, be on-trend and stay consistent. Algorithms favour frequency and silence is punished. If you

don’t post, you disappear.

There is an incessant pressure in that. You can have a brilliant service and still feel faintly anxious because you didn’t film anything. You can be exhausted and still feel the need to show up smiling in stories. Instagram is no longer optional for many creative professionals. It’s marketing, PR and community rolled into one.

Don’t get me wrong, it’s not all gloom and, yes, being seen is a conscious decision we take. Social media has many benefits. Discoverability is democratised. Anyone can build something from their own kitchen table. Between YouTube deep dives and TikTok teasers, anyone can learn the basics of almost any cuisine. As someone who cares deeply about food culture, that excites me. The walls coming down have allowed more voices in. More regional stories, more creativity and a lot more accountability.

The tension, however, is boundaries. Visibility is mistaken for availability and generosity for obligation. Transparency doesn’t mean total access. Sharing doesn’t mean surrendering everything. Just because you can reach someone instantly doesn’t mean they owe you a response, a recipe or an explanation.

I don’t have a neat solution. The truth is, as someone with over half-a-million followers, I’m grateful for the access, the attention and the conversations. Social media has allowed me to build restaurants and share ideas I never could have a decade ago.

But like any shared table, it works best when everyone remembers there are other people sitting around it. And if you really want the recipe, try asking nicely. You’d be surprised.

Karan Gokani is a London-based chef and restaurateur who spends his time cooking, travelling and exploring what the world is eating. He loves the gym, biryani and his frying pan. Not necessarily in that order.

Flower power

Sanjay Garg’s Raw Mango debuted at the London Fashion Week with Its Not About The Flowers

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Sanjay Garg has always been one to weave a story through his work with craft and community. On February 23, Raw Mango, a brand that has championed India’s craft and culture made a splash at the London Fashion Week.

The Fall/ Winter collection, It’s Not About The Flowers, was a celebration of the brand’s arrival in its own design language. Garlands were at the centre of it all, as a motif and a method. Attendees gathered at Westminster’s Royal Horticultural Halls, a befitting location for a designer whose irrevocable connection to flowers has stood the test of time through different collections. In attendance were sitarist Anoushka Shankar, director Gurinder Chadda and Akshata Murty, wife of the former Prime Minister of the UK, Rishi Sunak, among others.

“Flowers have always been a part of Raw Mango’s visuals, its stores, and our every day. I have been to every single flower market in India, and my curiosity also led me to consider working on a book on flowers and garlands,” Sanjay says. “I am fascinated by the garland, which is so much more than decoration. In my collection, it is not just beautifying the garment, it becomes the body and silhouette,” he adds.

On the runway, floral structures were reimagined and reconstructed, which included jasmine in full bloom as cut, hand-folded silk as well as flower buds in lycra, on flowy silhouettes or engineered into garments. A model sashayed down the ramp with suspended garlands worn over billowy black pants, and another donned flower buds as a structured top.

The show notes described



Sanjay Garg; (below) a model dons a Raw Mango creation at the London Fashion Week. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

hand-folded elements being assembled across silk brocade, Kanjivaram, paper-finished silk, rib-knit cotton, quilted silk, and handfelted wool, and indicated that the collection drew inspiration from floral gathri (sacks), suspended garlands, and the gestures through which they are bundled, transported, and displayed.

“I think the world, and us, are coming to terms with the fact that we have a unique product offering and a unique story to tell. What I showcase to the world is my India, and what I find beautiful,” Sanjay says.

It’s Not About The Flowers took shape over two and a half years, and Sanjay laughs, recalling being puzzled when he began his journey with no reference point, making hundreds of samples and going through rejections.

“There was so much to keep in mind; Raw Mango’s future, tradition and experimentation. We are chic, and I did not want anything very OTT. I wanted to make a couture garment, but also in a way that you can wear it more in life. Not every garment should be something that you cannot sit in,” he says, as he muses about having to strike a balance and keep the ethos of the brand in mind.



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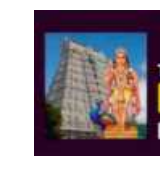
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Filmmaker Devi Prasad Shetty completes a hat-trick of cop movies starring Vijay Raghavendra with *Second Case of Seetharam*. It helps that Shetty has taken it a notch higher with every film. If *Seetharam Benoy* (2021) was a wannabe thriller, *Case of Kondana* (2024) was a thriller with a lot of purpose. On the flip side, the big reveals didn't feel organic. In his third movie, Shetty makes his most complete thriller yet. Despite a bumpy start, the movie gradually picks up to become a watchable, slow-burning crime thriller.

The sequel to *Seetharam Benoy* takes us back to the Anegedde police station in a fictional small town against a lush green backdrop. A series of gruesome murders puts the reputation of Inspector Seetharam (Vijay Raghavendra) at stake.

The film has a bumpy start. It takes itself too seriously while offering a routine experience of a crime thriller. The first 30 minutes of the plot are marred by cliches. There is a killer who is two steps ahead of the investigative officer. He could be a "cold-blooded psychopath", "as the forensic officer says. Of course, the cops have to see if he is leaving behind his signature after every murder. These elements are basic in any thriller and nothing unique for us to situp and notice. Some of the English dialogues ("I think we have got him", "I think it's started again") are unentionally silly because the state the obvious

Of course, it's improbable to reveal the killer far too early in the narrative while simultaneously sustaining interest. So, Gopalkrishna Deshpande plays a character meant to mislead you, only for the plot to spring a surprise later. Yet, his character arc is interesting enough to keep our curiosity intact.

The cinematography from Hemanth Acharya is one of the striking aspects of *Second Case of Seetharam*. The unconventional framing and the restless camera movement create an atmospheric feel. The staging of key scenes is impressive. The director uses slow motion to heighten the impact of the big reveals, ensuring we feel a sense of fear inside us.

Second Case of Seetharam could have benefited from an emotionally resonant protagonist. The story tries to give him a quintessential troubled past, but it's not explored in detail.

Seetharam remains an enigma for the viewers. Of course, he is good at his job. But, what does he think of his high-stressful and thankless job? Does he yearn for emotional support or companionship? Where does he get his sharp investigative skills? The movie doesn't delve into the mind of the protagonist.

This writing blip is compensated by how the film tracks the journey of the antagonist. It shows the psychology that drives the character to be a serial killer. The sequel doesn't jolt you, but it has some well-imagined twists. It is a restrained thriller that takes its time to produce the desired effect.

Second Case of Seetharam is currently running in theatres

Second Case
of Seetharam

Director: Devi Prasad Shetty

Cast: Vijay Raghavendra, Gopalkrishna Deshpande, Usha Bhandari

Runtime: 120 minutes

Storyline: Inspector Seetharam must track down a brutal, psychotic serial killer terrorising the town of Anegadde



A haunting meditation on systemic rot

Anurag Kashyap returns to his raw, uncompromising ways with a ticking-time-bomb of a film that rewards patience

Hindi

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Before the curtain rises on Anurag Kashyap's latest noirish adventure, William Wordsworth's famous words, "We poets in our youth begin in gladness; but thereof come in the end despondency and madness", flash on the screen. This struggle between resolution and independence holds for both Kashyap and *Kennedy*.

Curiously titled after South Indian star Vikram's real name, who was supposed to work with Kashyap once upon a time, *Kennedy* employs the underrated Rahul Bhat as a phantom cop, Uday Shetty, roaming in a rotting city.

Officially declared dead years earlier, he now exists as a shadowy hitman for a corrupt police commissioner, Rashid Khan (Mohit Takalkar), whose 'cut' has dried up during the COVID wave. Untethered and unseen, *Kennedy* is equally desperate as his boss and, in a quid pro quo, seeks information on the underworld don who destroyed his family life. Over the years, we have seen encounter specialists becoming a mirror image of the rot they set out to clean. In *Kennedy*, that figure steps out of the

Kennedy

Director: Anurag Kashyap

Duration: 135 minutes

Cast: Rahul Bhat, Sunny Leone, Mohit Takalkar, Megha Burman, Shrikant Yadav, Abhilash Thapliyal

Synopsis: A shadowy hitman executes kills for a corrupt Mumbai Police Commissioner in exchange for clues to the man who destroyed his family life.



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mirror and haunts. Uday's grim routine crosses paths with an enigmatic woman, Charlie (Sunny Leone). The intersection spirals into a hallucinatory contraption of guilt and revenge.

Set against the eerie backdrop of the pandemic-induced lockdown, the slow-burn simmers over dark nights of relentless violence and moral decadence in Mumbai. The subtle political commentary, wrapped in a heavy atmosphere, exposes how power operates through silence and erasure.

Those who traverse the newsscape will recognise that Kashyap, a keen observer of systemic decay, draws on the Antilla bomb scare of 2021 and weaves a complex web in which real-life cases of alleged corruption and extortion segue into fiction. It critiques how the politician-corporate nexus, intertwined with police and underworld elements are deeply entrenched in a rotten power structure where corruption thrives unchecked, even during crises. Though the film has been waiting in the wings for a while, the point it's trying to make remains relevant. In fact, with the advantage of hindsight, it is easier to join the dots now.

Cinematographer Sylvester Fonesca's gaze is at once intrusive and objective, and helps Kashyap use the pandemic's isolation to accentuate themes of alienation and loss. The storytelling prioritises mood over momentum. The punches don't bleed; they generate the

lingering pain of a contusion. Dotted with masked characters and deserted streets, the lighting and production design turn the metropolis into a sprawling yet claustrophobic trap.

Cast in a role that appears convoluted, Rahul makes the character's rage and existential crisis palpable. Anchoring a screenplay that feels at times fragmented, he generates both menace and vulnerability, sometimes in a single frame, to help us navigate the emotional architecture of the writing. Sunny subverts expectations as she plays a desperate woman, but her much-publicised nervous laugh, a defence mechanism to survive the monstrous turn of events, doesn't always fit the film's texture.

There are passages where *Kennedy* gives the impression that the arthouse tilt is a deliberate effort to say what is considered most politically incorrect without ruffling feathers. The scars of censorship can be felt in the language. The polish on the subversion is not uniform, and the role of editing in keeping us guessing is not seamless. Like the name of his new production house, Kashyap's films these days are good and bad without a conjunction. It is like *Kennedy* flows into *Nischanchi*. Both hold the gun with an unmistakable swagger. While the latter flatters to deceive, the former almost finds its target.

Kennedy is streaming on Zee5.

A reluctant nod to imperfect love

Hindi

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When the trailer of Ravi Udaywar's romantic drama *Do Deewane Seher Mein* surfaced online, one was hooked to the tune of Gulzar's melancholic *Do Deewane* (*Gharaonda*), searching for home and sustenance all over again. The haunting voice of Bhupinder Singh and the melody in Runa Laila's timbre continue to capture the dreams, hope, and loneliness that lovebirds face in big cities. However, it turns out that old gold is being refashioned to win over a new audience, but the carat is compromised in the process.

While the original was a stark, middle-class morality tale about housing desperation and disillusionment in Bombay, the new film shifts to a softer, personal lens that doesn't carry the moral weight of the title it flaunts.



It starts as the story of two socially awkward millennials in Mumbai who don't know how to market themselves in a see-me society and in a hear-me workplace. Hailing from Patna, Shashank (Siddhant Chaturvedi) is in a marketing job but suffers from a speech impediment, common among people from the Hindi heartland, where his 'sh' is reduced to 's'. This explains the missing 'h' in the title.

A content creator, Roshni (Mrunal

Thakur), works in a fashion magazine but is conscious of her features and body type: no nail art, no contact lenses. The film suggests that arranged marriage is the way out for such boys and girls. So, their parents bring them together, and over the next couple of hours, Shashank and Roshni heal each other's complexes and, in the process, teach us that imperfections are fine.

Though shot tastefully, the

screenwriting and treatment are bland and overstretched. It is a Sanjay Leela Bhansali production where the flaws are charming, but the spark is missing. And the words that add spice to the proceedings have been muted. Conversations on body positivity and inclusivity in fashion are not new. Similarly, with the advent of private news channels, the purity of language is no longer a concern in living rooms and boardrooms. So when the makers hang the story on the twin pegs, the conflict seems overstated.

The mental block, though real, remains on paper. When Shashank suggests what seems easy to others, it becomes a mountain to climb for him; it rings a bell, but the sentiment seldom seeps through the screen to grip you. While it avoids being overly melodramatic, it also shies away from deeper confrontation with the city's harsher realities. It seems the protagonists and their problems are planted in a world they don't belong to.

Perhaps, newcomers from mofussil towns making their way in Mumbai would have been a better

way to explore the idea but the makers perhaps feel that the multiplex audience won't be able to face reality during the Valentine's week.

In the absence of solid material,

Do Deewane
Seher Mein

Director: Ravi Udaywar

Cast: Siddhant Chaturvedi, Mrunal Thakur, Viraj Ghelani, Ila Arun, Ayesha Raza Mishra, Sandeepa Dhar, Joy Sengupta, Deepraj Rana, Achint Kaur

Runtime: 138 minutes

Storyline: The romantic follows a corporate professional hindered by a childhood speech impediment, and a content creator grappling with deep insecurities about her appearance and self-worth.

Siddhant and Mrunal fail to generate any tangible frisson. The big spectacles, and the stutter in speech seldom feel lived in. When they don't become characters, it becomes difficult to believe in Shashank and Roshni's lack of confidence.

Mrunal doesn't seem to be conscious of her looks. In fact, she looks chic. Her insecurities look silly and out of place. Apart from the occasional stutter, Siddhant looks like a cool dude living in a sea-facing apartment. The complex about speech doesn't reflect in his personality, and the cure he gets was always with him. The support cast has some big names, but they all play along as if a pay cheque is the only motivation.

When the writing doesn't fully trust its premise of introspective character study, it leans on convenient emotional beats or predictable insecurities rather than letting the awkwardness breathe longer. Too quiet, too safe!

Do Deewane Seher Mein is currently running in theatres.

Good Luck, Have Fun, Don't Die

Director: Gore Verbinski

Cast: Sam Rockwell, Haley Lu Richardson, Michael Peña, Zazie Beetz, Asim Chaudhry, Juno Temple

Runtime: 134 minutes

Storyline: A man from the future tries to recruit people from a diner to stop the end of the world



Unlimited glee in the end-times comedy

English

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Science fiction can be heavy and allegorical or light-hearted and still put across a serious message. Gore Verbinski's return to the director's chair after a 10-year-break offers a movie from the latter category. Well-beloved sci-fi themes from AI becoming self-aware to time loops and visitors from the future are presented in a bouncy, nerdy, fizzy manner. The movie is presided over by Sam Rockwell's "man from the future" having a blast and sweeping us along on a tidal wave of energy.

At 10.10 pm in an LA diner, a man in a transparent raincoat with all sorts of weird accoutrements announces himself as coming from the future and needing volunteers to stop the end of the world. The man is from a blasted future where people got so involved with their virtual lives that they did not realise food and other essential supplies had run out till it was too late. The people at the diner when they are able to drag their eyes from their devices believe him somewhat. This time around, after telling Gerald, who puts up his hand to help in stopping the apocalypse, the man forces Scott (Asim Chaudhry), Bob (Daniel Barnett), Marie (Georgia Goodman), Mark (Michael Peña) and Janet (Zazie Beetz) to join in the revolution. Two women, Susan (Juno Temple) and Ingrid (Haley Lu Richardson) volunteer and the man allows them to join after an initial hesitation. We learn about the backgrounds and past lives of some of the team. Mark and Janet were teachers and when Mark got mesmerised by one of his student's phones and touched it, the students seem to have been activated by a similar image on their phones to attack Mark and Janet.

Susan loses her son, Darren (Riccardo Drayton), to a school shooting. Upon hearing of a company that can bring her son back in the form of a clone, Susan is distressed by the clone Darren's unnerving strangeness. Ingrid has a condition where she cannot be around Wi-Fi and seems to find her groove by being a princess at children's birthday parties and finding a kindred spirit in Tim (Tom Taylor). Verbinski, who has done some heavy-duty genre hopping with *The Ring* and the *Pirates of the Caribbean* movies, injects *Good Luck, Have Fun, Don't Die* with a kind of unhinged fun that is attractive once you sign on for the ride. There are a host of clever ideas and prescient worries that Verbinski asks us to think about, delivered in his signature blend of playful chaos, driving music, and heart. And even if one does not want to think of the horror of being tethered to devices, *Good Luck, Have Fun, Don't Die* is all kinds of clever fun with Rockwell's outrageous performance propelling the film to zany heights.

Good Luck, Have Fun, Don't Die is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Alia Bhatt turns presenter during BAFTA Awards ceremony, begins speech in Hindi

At the recently-held BAFTA Awards, Bollywood star Alia Bhatt made her debut as a presenter as she announced the award for Best Film Not in the English Language. In a surprising move, the actor started her speech in Hindi, "Namaskar! Agla award ek aisi film ke liye hai, jo angrezi mein nahi hai (Greetings. The next award is for a film that is not in English). The award in the category went to Joachim Trier's *Sentimental Value*. Alia wore a custom silver Gucci dress and donned a white stole to complement it. On the work front, Alia will be seen next in Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Love & War*, co-starring Ranbir Kapoor and Vicky Kaushal.



A throbbing yaoi fantasy

The Canadian phenom is what it looks like when queer erotica escapes the archive and builds an entire series around exactly what everyone was hoping would happen

English Russian

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If you've ever devoured enemies-to-lovers smut while mentally reaching for a Victorian fainting couch, *Heated Rivalry* is already fluent in these age-old fanfic indulgences. The hit Canadian romance fully understands the pleasures of watching two hyper-competent men feigning immunity to longing while circling each other like sharks in heat who keep brushing fins. It never plays coy about those tropes, because its makers clocked our collective motivations instantly and saw no reason to waste precious screen time pretending you didn't show up ready to enjoy every last second of it. That self-awareness is part of what turns *Heated Rivalry* into something more potent than the average queer romance. Created and directed by Jacob Tierney, the series adapts Rachel Reid's hockey romance, *Game Changers*, in six-episodes of well-funded AO3 wish fulfilment. The cultural shockwave that has followed in its wake has been impressive. The indie Canadian production led by relatively unknown actors quickly became a global fixation, inciting think pieces, thirst edits, and endless debates about who is allowed to enjoy watching men touch each other this tenderly. The premise is titillating. Two guys – the serene, buttoned-down Canadian captain Shane Hollander, played with immaculately calibrated vulnerability by Hudson Williams, and the cocky,

Heated Rivalry

Creator: Jacob Tierney

Cast: Hudson Williams, Connor Storrie, François Arnaud, Robbie G.K., Christina Chang, Ksenia Daniela Kharlamova, Sophie Nélisse, and Dylan Walsh

Episodes: 6

Runtime: 43-55 minutes

Storyline: A romance set in the world of hockey; Shane Hollander and Ilya Rozanov are two stars in Major League Hockey, bound by ambition, rivalry, and a magnetic pull neither of them fully understands

bracingly handsome Russian rival Ilya Rozanov, played by Connor Storrie – meet on opposing sides of a hockey rivalry, whose animosity is meant to sell tickets and headlines. The problem arises once their first late-night encounter rewires that antagonism into an incognito arrangement built on forbidden sex and a shared appetite for winning. Tierney structures the story with a provocative confidence. The show declines the traditional romance crawl toward courtship and consummation and instead leaps into bed within minutes, stretching the consequences across years through aggressive time jumps that mirror the itinerant rhythm of a sporting season. Across the first half of the show, Shane and Ilya meet in hotels where the lighting stays low and pretty, use pseudonyms to sext in locker rooms, and mischievously tease each other in public – all of this simmers under the violent syntax of professional hockey's stop-and-start life. And so the narrative pressure does not come from the anticipation of all the hot, steamy and gorgeously-shot sex, but the accumulation of feeling that all the sex keeps failing to discharge. Williams plays Shane like someone permanently bracing for impact, with tight smiles and fidgety silences which make his desire feel carefully rationed. Storrie counters that energy with a performance built on machismo, selling Ilya's confidence as a layer of swagger he keeps weaponising whenever the ground shifts beneath him. The duo's tremendous chemistry feels charged with calculation and want, and each clandestine reunion carries the faint panic of people who understand the stakes and choose to give in to desire anyway. The decision to interrupt this central

dynamic with a detour into fellow-hockey rival Scott Hunter (François Arnaud) and his barista love-interest Kip Grady's (Robbie Graham-Kuntz) relationship in the third episode clarifies the series' broader architecture. Scott's closeted terror and Kip's refusal to accept invisibility provide a parallel case study that reframes Shane and Ilya's choices without preaching. One of the show's greatest strengths is watching it take the usual bluster of locker-room masculinity and slowly sand it down into something warmer and far more watchable, especially once the final stretch forces these two to stop posturing and actually look at each other. When they finally retreat to the fabled 'cottage' of internet lore, the competitive sniping softens into a tentative honesty that feels earned, with their egos finally benched long enough for a *real* man-to-man. Erotic fantasy is a sandbox that gives both queer and straight audiences room to experiment with what they want, what they recognise, and what they might someday claim. The online discourse keeps pointing back to fanfiction and fujoshi culture as incubators of desire that could be tested without consequence, which is why stories like *Heated Rivalry* operate by different rules, loosening the hierarchies that dominate real-world sex and replacing them with systems built around curiosity and negotiation. *Heated Rivalry's* success lies in treating fantasy as a legitimate site of meaning rather than an indulgence to be somehow justified. Sometimes the cultural intervention arrives through praxis, and sometimes it arrives through two men who cannot keep their hands off each other despite every incentive to stop. Both can coexist.

Heated Rivalry is currently streaming on Lionsgate Play



Toxic: Yash confirms dual role, second avatar named Ticket

Kannada superstar Yash, gearing up for the release of *Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Up*, has confirmed that he would be playing dual roles in the pan-Indian movie. Yash took to social media to reveal the name of his second avatar in the action drama directed by Geetu Mohandas. While the character that was shown in the previously released teaser is called Raya, the new clean-shaven character is called Ticket. Speculations are rife that the actor is playing a father-son duo in the movie, which is set to hit the screens on March 19. Produced by KVN Productions, *Toxic* also stars Nayanthara, Kiara Advani, Huma Qureshi, Rukmini Vasanth and Tara Sutaria.



Rishab Shetty begins shoot for Prasanth Varma's mythological epic Jai Hanuman

The upcoming mythological film *Jai Hanuman*, starring Rishab Shetty in the role of Hanuman, was launched this week with a puja held at Anjanadri Betta in Karnataka, a site widely regarded as the birthplace of lord Hanuman. Directed by Prasanth Varma, it marks Rishab's first full-fledged role following his National Award-winning performance in *Kantara*. The project serves as a follow-up to 2024's *Hanu-Man*; while *Hanu-Man* centred on a superhero inspired by the deity, *Jai Hanuman* will directly chronicle the story of lord Hanuman. The film is part of the expanding Prasanth Varma Cinematic Universe (PVCU).